Teach Them Diligently

Faith is passed to the next generation when God's word is first in our own hearts and then woven into everyday family life.

Main passage	Deuteronomy 6:4-9 (KJV)
Topic	Children
Audience	adults
Length	about 45 minutes
Status	Draft: written by AI from the library, not yet reviewed by Dave

Suggested timing

Opening	4 min
Scripture	3 min
Background	5 min
Teaching point 1: Love God with everything	7 min
Teaching point 2: God's word first in our own hearts	7 min
Teaching point 3: Teach diligently in everyday life	7 min
Discussion questions	7 min
Application	3 min
Closing prayer	2 min
Total	45 min

Opening (4 min)

Ask: "Who taught you about God when you were young? Was it more by what they said or by how they lived?" Let several people share. Encourage grandparents, aunts and uncles, Sunday School teachers and godparents, as well as parents, to see themselves in today's lesson.

Teacher note: Some class members may be grieving children who have wandered from faith, or may not have children. Emphasize that every Christian has a part in passing on the faith, and that God's grace is greater than our failures.

Scripture (3 min)

Deuteronomy 6:4-9

4 Hear, O Israel: The LORD our God is one LORD: 5 And thou shalt love the LORD thy God with all thine heart, and with all thy soul, and with all thy might. 6 And these words, which I command thee this day, shall be in thine heart: 7 And thou shalt teach them diligently unto thy children, and shalt talk of them when thou sittest in thine house, and when thou walkest by the way, and when thou liest down, and when thou risest

up. [8] And thou shalt bind them for a sign upon thine hand, and they shall be as frontlets between thine eyes. [9] And thou shalt write them upon the posts of thy house, and on thy gates.

Read the passage aloud. Explain that verses 4-5 are called the Shema, from the Hebrew word for "Hear."

Background (5 min)

Deuteronomy records Moses' final speeches to Israel just before they entered the Promised Land. A whole new generation had grown up in the wilderness. Moses knew that once they were settled and prosperous, they could easily forget God (6:10-12).

Verses 4-5 became the central confession of Israel's faith, recited daily by faithful Jews to this day. Jesus called verse 5 "the first and great commandment" (Matthew 22:37-38). Verses 6-9 describe how this faith is to be passed down: not just in formal lessons, but at home, on the road, at bedtime and at breakfast.

Teaching point 1: Love God with everything (7 min)

"Hear, O Israel: The LORD our God is one LORD: and thou shalt love the LORD thy God with all thine heart, and with all thy soul, and with all thy might" (vv. 4-5). Before parenting advice comes the foundation: there is one God, and he deserves our whole love. We cannot pass on what we do not have.

Supporting verses

Deuteronomy 6:4-5: Hear, O Israel: The LORD our God is one LORD: And thou shalt love the LORD thy God with all thine heart, and with all thy soul, and with all thy might.

Matthew 22:37-38: Jesus said unto him, Thou shalt love the Lord thy God with all thy heart, and with all thy soul, and with all thy mind. This is the first and great commandment.

Mark 12:29-30: And Jesus answered him, The first of all the commandments is, Hear, O Israel; The Lord our God is one Lord: And thou shalt love the Lord thy God with all thy heart, and with all thy soul, and with all thy mind, and with all thy strength: this is the first commandment.

> *"A brief summary of religion, containing the first principles of faith and obedience"*
> — Matthew Henry, Commentary on the Whole Bible, on Deuteronomy 6:4-16

Handout blanks (answers)

The LORD our God is one **LORD**.

Love the LORD thy God with all thine heart, soul, and **might**.

Teaching point 2: God's word first in our own hearts (7 min)

"And these words ... shall be in thine heart" (v. 6). Teaching children begins with the teacher's own heart. Children quickly sense whether faith is real to us or just a Sunday habit. Adam Clarke puts it simply:

Supporting verses

Deuteronomy 6:6: And these words, which I command thee this day, shall be in thine heart:

Psalm 119:11: Thy word have I hid in mine heart, that I might not sin against thee.

2 Timothy 1:5: When I call to remembrance the unfeigned faith that is in thee, which dwelt first in thy grandmother Lois, and thy mother Eunice; and I am persuaded that in thee also.

> *"For where else can love be? If it be not in the heart, it exists not."*
> — Adam Clarke, Commentary on the Bible, on Deuteronomy 6:6

Handout blanks (answers)

These words shall be in thine **heart**.

We cannot pass on a faith we do not **have**.

Teaching point 3: Teach diligently in everyday life (7 min)

"Thou shalt teach them diligently unto thy children, and shalt talk of them when thou sittest in thine house, and when thou walkest by the way, and when thou liest down, and when thou risest up" (v. 7). Clarke notes the Hebrew word for "teach diligently" means to repeat again and again, the way a blade is sharpened. Faith is passed on mostly in ordinary moments: meals, car rides, bedtimes and daily conversation.

Supporting verses

Deuteronomy 6:7-9: And thou shalt teach them diligently unto thy children, and shalt talk of them when thou sittest in thine house, and when thou walkest by the way, and when thou liest down, and when thou risest up. And thou shalt bind them for a sign upon thine hand, and they shall be as frontlets between thine eyes. And thou shalt write them upon the posts of thy house, and on thy gates.

Proverbs 22:6: Train up a child in the way he should go: and when he is old, he will not depart from it.

Ephesians 6:4: And, ye fathers, provoke not your children to wrath: but bring them up in the nurture and admonition of the Lord.

> *"to repeat, iterate, or do a thing again and again; hence to whet or sharpen any instrument"*
> — Adam Clarke, Commentary on the Bible, on Deuteronomy 6:7

Handout blanks (answers)

Thou shalt teach them **diligently** unto thy children.

Faith is passed on mostly in **ordinary (everyday)** moments.

Discussion questions (7 min)

1. Why do you think the command to love God comes before the command to teach children?

We can only pass on what is real in us; love for God is the source of faithful teaching.

2. What are the "sitting, walking, lying down, rising up" moments in a family's life today?

Meals, drives to school, bedtime, mornings, holidays, chores.

3. What helped faith become real to you as a child, and what did not?

Answers will vary; often example, warmth and honest answers matter more than lectures.

4. How can those without children at home take part in passing on the faith?

Teaching Sunday School, mentoring, praying for children by name, being a godly example, supporting parents.

Application (3 min)

Choose one "everyday moment" this week to talk about God naturally with a child or young person in your life: a story at bedtime, a question in the car, a prayer at a meal. If you have no children at home, write to or pray for a child or young person by name each day.

Closing prayer (2 min)

Lord our God, you are the one Lord. Teach us to love you with all our heart, soul and might. Put your words deep in our hearts, and give us wisdom and patience to pass them on to our children and grandchildren in everyday life. Where we have failed, cover our failures with your grace, and draw the next generation to yourself. Amen.

Sources quoted

Matthew Henry, Commentary on the Whole Bible, on Deuteronomy 6:4-16

Adam Clarke, Commentary on the Bible, on Deuteronomy 6:6

Adam Clarke, Commentary on the Bible, on Deuteronomy 6:7

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